

TANK DESTRUCTION

Iraqi armored forces had no defense against pinpoint air strikes once they had been identified as a target by America's "eyes in the sky." The A-10 Warthog was the Americans' primary tank-busting aircraft, but any airplane armed with JDAMS or other guided munitions could be directed to strike Saddam's tanks.

seen as the United States' prime enemies. The Pentagon's 2006 Defense Review Report envisaged a future in which America's "new and elusive foes" would need to be "found,

fixed, and finished" anywhere around the globe. An expanded force of UAVs would be a crucial part of a combined intelligence effort to identify targets. Destroying these targets would require a new bomber aircraft capable of hitting any spot on Earth. This newcomer would join existing B-1s, B-2s, and a slimmed-down force of B-52s as a precision strike force that might well attack targets in countries with which America was not at war and might operate in support of non-American ground forces.

Operations of this kind did indeed become commonplace for American and other NATO states in the early 21st century, from the invasion of Afghanistan in 2001 through to later interventions in Libya and Syria. Wherever possible, commitment on the ground was restricted to a handful of special forces, the costly face-to-face combat left to local fighters benefiting from Western air support. The use of precision air strikes, usually by unmanned aircraft, to assassinate leaders of anti-Western movements became an accepted practice.

LONG-LIVED WARTHOG

The A-10 Thunderbolt, better known as the Warthog, pummeled Iraqi armor in 2003 as it had in 1991. First flown in 1972, the Warthog is likely to remain in service until 2028 – a striking example of the longevity of some current military aircraft.

which civilian casualties were a sensitive issue, aircraft were useful but not decisive and, importantly, could not prevent the need for face-to-face fighting in urban areas or stop terrorists from operating. Iraq confirmed the point once made by air historian John Buckley, that "Air power was an excellent weapon of major war, but of limited use in low-intensity conflicts restricted by political considerations."

Future wars

The US Defense Department had the difficult task of conceiving a credible plan for the effective use of America's power and precision in the air against the "dispersed, global terrorist networks" and "rogue states" that after 2001 were

DESERT PATROL

US helicopters fly over the Iraqi desert during counter-insurgency operations. The challenge of bringing air power to bear against an elusive enemy was one the United States faced not only in post-invasion Iraq, but also on a wider global scale.

